

Stirling Old Town Walk - Kids

UK Family Tour

The Secret Town Down the Hill

Here is a bonus adventure, if you feel like walking. The castle you just explored sits right at the top of a big, steep hill, and tumbling down that hill, like toys spilled off a shelf, is a whole old town. It is hundreds of years old, and we can walk down through it, all the way to a very old bridge by the river. And the best part? It's downhill the whole way.

So imagine you are leaving the castle behind you and stepping into the town where ordinary people lived. Not kings and queens, but the bakers and blacksmiths and merchants, the children and the thieves and the town crier shouting out the news.

As we walk down, keep your eyes open, because we are going to pass some amazing things. A grand stone house, all covered in fancy carvings, built by the man whose job was to guard the castle. An old, old church where something incredible once happened, a baby was crowned king right inside it. A spooky Victorian jail where you might meet the jailer. A market square with a stone unicorn on top of a cross. And right at the bottom, an old stone bridge with a secret about a battle.

Ready? Every stop has a story. Some are funny, one or two are a little bit yucky, and one is quite spooky. Let's head down the hill and find them, one at a time.

The Baby Who Was Crowned King

Come inside this old, old church. It is called the Church of the Holy Rude, and it is the oldest building in the whole town except for the castle. Look straight up. See that dark wooden roof? It was built about six hundred years ago, and it's held together with wooden pegs, like the world's biggest, cleverest jigsaw puzzle. No nails at all. And it has never once fallen down.

Now for the big story. Remember how, up in the castle, you heard that Mary, Queen of Scots was crowned when she was just a baby? Well, Mary grew up and became a real queen. But then something sad happened. Her enemies took her crown away and locked her up. And they decided to make somebody else king instead. Guess who? Her own little boy, just over one year old. A baby in nappies.

So right here, in this very church, in the year 1567, they crowned a baby as King of Scotland. His name was James, and one day he would be king of England too. Imagine it. A wriggling one year old, a crown far too big for his head, and a grumpy old preacher called John Knox giving a very long, very serious speech, while the baby probably just wanted his lunch.

So think about this for a second. Mary was crowned as a baby up in the castle. Her son was crowned as a baby down here in the town. Same family, same little hill, and both of them too young even to walk.

When we go back outside, look at the graveyard on the slope, hundreds of tilting old stones, some so old the writing has worn clean away. One more funny fact about the church. For almost three hundred years, a wall ran right down the middle inside, splitting it into two churches, because two groups of people

had an argument and didn't want to share. Imagine building a wall down the middle of your house just because you fell out with your sister.

The Spooky Old Jail

Keep walking down and you will come to a building that looks a bit like a mini castle, with a round tower. But this was no home for kings. This was the town jail, the place where they locked up robbers, cheats and troublemakers. If it's open, you can go inside, and a guide dressed up as a real Victorian jailer might show you around, rattling the big iron keys and telling you exactly what happened to people who ended up here. Are you brave enough?

Before this jail was built, prisoners were kept in a horrible little building down in the market square. It was so dirty, so smelly, and so crammed full of people that a man whose job was to check on prisons came to visit, held his nose, and wrote down that it was one of the worst jails in the entire country. Yuck.

So in the year 1847, they built this new one, and it was meant to be much better. And it was cleaner. But it had a strange, spooky rule. Every single prisoner had to stay completely silent, all the time, alone in their own little cell. No talking, no laughing, no chatting to the person next door, for months and months and months. Imagine not being allowed to say a single word for a whole year. The people in charge thought that all that silence would somehow make the prisoners good again. Instead, being so lonely and so quiet just made many of them terribly sad.

Inside, your guide will show you the tiny cells and tell you about the hangman, and the clever tricks prisoners used when they tried to escape. It's a little bit scary and a little bit sad, but it tells you something true. The town we are walking through was beautiful for some people, and not one tiny bit beautiful for others.

The Show-Off Houses of the Nobles

Look at this enormous stone wall, covered all over in carvings, right at the top of the street. It is called Mar's Wark, and "wark" is just an old Scottish way of saying "building." The funny thing is, it's almost all show and no house. If you peek behind that grand, fancy front, there is hardly anything there at all. It is like a giant stage set, or the front of a cardboard castle.

Why would someone build a house that is mostly just a fancy front? Well, the man who built it, the Earl of Mar, had an important job. His family were the guards of Stirling Castle. For years and years, it was their job to protect the castle, and even to help look after the royal children who grew up inside it. So the Earl wanted everyone walking up to the castle to see just how grand and important he was. He built this show-off wall, all covered in carved figures and animals, right where nobody could possibly miss it. People even say he took the stones for it from an old abbey nearby. Sneaky.

A little further along is another posh house, called Argyll's Lodging, and this one is not a trick, it's real and complete. It is the fanciest old town house left in all of Scotland. One of the men who owned it spent so much money making it beautiful, hoping the king would come and visit, that he ran right out of money and ended up owing coins to just about everybody.

So that's the whole idea of this street. Up the hill, the king and queen lived in the grandest place of all, the castle. And all the rich, important nobles wanted to live as close to the king as they possibly could, in the fanciest houses they could build. A bit like everyone crowding to sit next to the most popular kid at lunchtime.

The Unicorn on the Cross

Keep going and the street opens up wide. This was the marketplace, the busiest, noisiest, smelliest place in the whole old town. Try to imagine it long ago. Wooden stalls everywhere, chickens squawking, a fish seller shouting, a man selling shoes, another selling cloth, mud and straw all over the ground, and the smell, oh, the smell of fish and animals and smoke. This was where everyone came to buy their food and to hear the news.

Look for the tall stone monument in the middle, the market cross. And look right at the very top. See it? A stone unicorn, Scotland's magic royal animal. It has stood up there for hundreds of years, and the people of Stirling gave it a funny nickname. They call it the Puggy. Nobody is quite sure why, but the name stuck.

This cross was the town's special centre. When the king had important news, a man would stand right here and shout it out loud to the whole crowd, because there were no phones, no televisions, and most people could not read a newspaper.

Now look at the building keeping watch over the square. It's called the Tolbooth, and it did about four jobs all at once. It was the town hall, where the important people held their meetings. It was the courtroom, where they decided if you were guilty. It was where everyone paid their taxes. And it was the jail.

Now for the yucky part. Long ago, punishments happened right out here in the square, in front of everybody. If you did something wrong, they might lock a heavy iron collar around your neck, chained to the wall, and leave you standing there all day while everyone walked past and laughed and pointed. That was your punishment, being embarrassed in front of the whole town. Imagine being stuck in the middle of a busy market with an iron collar on, unable to run and hide. People were very tough on troublemakers back then.

The Bridge With a Battle Secret

Our walk finishes down by the river, at an old stone bridge. And this bridge holds a secret that connects all the way back to the castle. Do you remember the story of the brave warrior William Wallace, and the great battle at Stirling Bridge? Way back in the year 1297, Wallace won a huge battle right here by the river, by waiting until half of the enemy army had crossed a narrow wooden bridge, and then attacking.

Well, that wooden bridge is long gone now. But look at the strong stone bridge standing here, with its four graceful arches. This one was built to replace it, about five hundred years ago. For hundreds and hundreds of years, this was the only proper way to cross the river and get up into the Highlands. If you wanted to go north, you crossed right here, and you might even have to pay a coin to do it, like a toll on a road.

Now for the bridge's own exciting secret. In the year 1745, an army was marching toward Stirling, led by a prince nicknamed Bonnie Prince Charlie. The soldiers up in the castle did not want that army to cross the bridge. So what do you think they did? They blew up one of the arches. Boom. They smashed a great big hole in their own bridge, just to stop the enemy getting across. It worked, and later on they fixed the hole right back up again.

Now look around for the old stone town wall. Stirling built a wall all the way around part of the town, and can you guess why? To keep enemies out. And they built it in a big hurry, to protect somebody very special, a baby, the little Mary, Queen of Scots, because an English king was trying to snatch her away. So the whole town turned itself into a kind of castle, with walls to keep their baby queen safe.

So we finish exactly where the castle's story began, at the bridge and the walls. A whole town, built to guard a country, a river crossing, and one very small queen.